Ashes for the first time in twenty-four years, but I wanted to win them, outright.

I'm puritanical when it comes to performance. Losing in Sydney would have meant a drawn series, which wouldn't have felt right. Would we lapse into old habits? Would we be up for it, mentally? Had we retained our hunger? Sad, perhaps, but I was nervous, even as I watched the New Year's Eve fireworks from an apartment overlooking the Sydney Harbour Bridge.

Ricky Ponting and Ryan Harris were injured. Australia were in disarray, but they still had their oath of allegiance to the Baggy Green. We were in for one of those tug of wars, when weakness, once sensed, builds before it bursts. They got to 105 for the loss of one wicket before Brez had Shane Watson caught, and defiance seeped away.

The best teams take pride in their superiority, reinforce it in pivotal phases. Straussy seized the initiative from the off, and I made the most of my good fortune, in being caught off a no-ball. I was in unprecedented rhythm and cursed the lazy drive that cost me a double hundred. Ian Bell and Matty Prior compensated with centuries; once we were out for 644 it was a matter of when, not if.

We were taken into a fifth day, warmed by the memory of the previous evening's skewering of Mitchell Johnson. The crowd were living it; they, too, sensed it was our time and their place. An entire stand serenaded Johnson with his song all the way to the wicket, once Chris Tremlett had bounced Haddin out.

'He bowls to the left. He bowls to the right. Mitchell Johnson, your batting is shite …'

Chris was a big, intimidating guy, but wasn't express pace. As I delivered the ball to him from mid-on he murmured, 'I'm just going to try and bowl this as fast as I can.' He produced an absolute jaffa, which swung in and splayed the stumps. The next few seconds were almost surreal.

It was bedlam. The crowd's roar could have been heard in Auckland. Johnson, accompanied by TV's cartoon duck, was serenaded all the way back to the pavilion. He would exact his revenge, three years later, but you couldn't do anything other than laugh. When I saw Henry, my brother-in-law, later, he summed up the mood by saying he never needed to see another away Test match.

There was the usual champagne-soaked scrum in the changing room before we decided to take a few beers out to the square for a debrief. We